Srila Vamshidasa Babaji Maharaja

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A Paramahamsa in the Guise of an Avadhuta

Srila Vamshidasa Babaji Maharaja was a saint of Navadvipa in the first half of the twentieth century, whom the disciples of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati remembered with reverence and with caution. The journal “Gaudiya” called him Om Vishnupada Sri Srila Vamshidasa Babaji Maharaja, or more often simply Srila Babaji Maharaja or Baba; the best of avadhutas (avadhuta-vara) and the crown jewel of the line of paramahamsas, the foremost of maha-bhagavatas, a great soul free in every respect (sarva-tantra-svatantra). Others called him Srila Vamshi Dasa Babaji, Vamshi Dasaji or Mahatma Vamshi Dasa, and one of the biographies calls him “the Paramahamsa Avadhuta”.

He was a paramahamsa Vaishnava who lived as an avadhuta — a wanderer not bound by outward rules. An avadhuta has shaken off every worldly feeling and obligation, takes no account of social custom, above all of the rules of varnashrama, and is unusual in his conduct; Sri Nityananda too is often called an avadhuta. The little we know of him has been preserved in old articles of the journal “Gaudiya” and in the accounts of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta and his disciples, who knew Babaji personally.

The chronicle of the “Gaudiya” sees in him a boundless mercy dependent on nothing. For the sake of souls who have turned away from the Lord, are bound by maya and tormented by the threefold miseries, he displayed the pastime of wandering through holy places, towns and villages. The dust of his feet purified the earth, and simple people who saw him and served him, “the beloved of Vaikuntha”, received true good fortune.

Homeland and Former Life

He was born in the village of Majidpur near the town of Jamalpur in East Bengal (now Bangladesh); before the partition of India this area belonged to the district of Mymensingh. According to Haridasa Dasa, his father's name was Sanatana Malobrahma, and before leaving the world he himself was called Bhairava. The year and day of his birth have not been preserved.

Of his former life he spoke sparingly and always with self-effacement: “In those days, in my former ashrama, I lived on the other bank of the Brahmaputra.” “Without serving father or mother, I took a kaupina and left.” “I know neither the work of the Vedas nor the work of the injunctions.” And once he sighed: “I am in accord with none of the four sampradayas — what will become of me?”[1]

He also recalled the bad company in which he had once lived: he named his former companions, who bore the name of Vaishnavas, and told of their unworthy deeds, but added that while living among them he never mixed with them and performed his bhajana as it should be done. He had little love for his native land. When devotees from Majidpur invited him there, he yielded to their eagerness, but found no joy in the journey and said that this was a place the Pandavas had disdained. He said the same in Bhagalpur: “Majidpur is a land the Pandavas left behind: the people are ill-natured, they eat anything, there is no Harinama. I have no place of my own; like the Pandavas in exile, I live unrecognised in the forest.” But with a fellow countryman, Gokula Dasa Babaji, an elderly godbrother of Srila Bhakti Pramoda Puri Goswami Maharaj, who often came to him, he spoke joyfully of Krishna in his native Mymensingh dialect.

Beneath a Tree by the Ganga

From East Bengal he came to Navadvipa and settled on the bank of the Ganga. He lived in the highest renunciation: under a tree on the bank, and he also had a hut by the river. “In Navadvipa I lived on alms,” he said. “To eat another's rice is good, but to live under another's roof is not.” He wore only a kaupina and neither cut nor groomed his hair or beard. He was so tall that he could pick fruit for puja from the upper branches without a ladder; but once he fell from a tree — and from then on he showed the form of a lame man.

He seemed not to notice the offerings people brought. They brought him rice, fruit, vegetables, flour and bananas; when much had gathered, he offered it all to his Deities in his mind and distributed the remnants to whoever happened to be near. The door of his hut was never locked, though well-wishers begged him to lock it, and thieves again and again carried off everything inside. When asked about it he replied that guarding the house and its things was the concern of Gaura-Nitai — and at times he himself scolded the Deities for not stopping the thieves[2].

Once he gathered fruit by his hut for his Deities and allowed no one to touch it. In the night a thief carried off the Deities' utensils, and in the morning a cow wandered in and ate all the fruit; no one could drive her out. But Babaji laughed and clapped his hands: “One thief gives, another thief takes!” — for the greatest thief is Krishna Himself. A disciple named Purna (or Punya) lived with him.

Deities in Two Cloth Bags

His Deities lived in two cloth bags: in one, Nitai-Gaura; in the other, Radha-Govinda. Regularly he took Them out, served Them in his mind with mantras, and carefully put Them back; and at times he left Them outside so that people, too, could have Their darshana. The chronicle of the “Gaudiya” calls Them the Deities of his bhava-seva — service in divine feeling; Babaji called his Deity simply “Thakura” or “Sri Gopala”.

He spoke more with his Deities than with people: he laughed with Them, and at times wept in despair; at night he talked with Thakura and joyfully sang to Him. In temples, too, he spoke quietly with the Deities, revealing to Them his innermost heart. At times he offered tobacco in a hookah to Radha and Govinda — but never to Nitai-Gauranga[3].

Srila Gaurakishora and the Acharyas of the Gaudiya Math

The chronicle of the “Gaudiya” calls him a follower of Srila Gaurakishora Dasa Babaji Maharaja: in his life one sees the same examples of restraining and instructing worldly people as in the life of Srila Gaurakishora.

When Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, having left Puri, came to Navadvipa, Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura introduced him to Babaji. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta was drawn by his Vaishnava conduct and his complete disregard for social convention. He himself bowed to Babaji from a distance, but did not allow his disciples to associate with him: a beginner might misunderstand his indifference to rules and offend his feet. The rules of sadhana, one of the biographies explains, exist above all for the pleasure of Radha-Govinda and for the growth of the beginner; whoever measures a perfected Vaishnava by the standards of a sadhaka risks committing an offence and falling from the path of devotion.

He allowed no one to touch his feet. Only once — on the day after Phalguna Purnima, when the festival Jagannatha Mishra held for the birth of Gauranga was being remembered — he forgot his rule in ecstasy, and Srila Bhakti Pramoda Puri Goswami Maharaj received the dust of his feet; on another occasion he also received the remnants of his prasada. Srila Puri Maharaj remembered other words of his as well. Hearing someone sing the line “tyajiya shayana-sukha, vichitra palanka…” — “leaving the comfort of sleep on an ornate bed…” — Babaji said: “You are only singing a song. It reveals itself only

to one who has himself been opened”[4]. And when someone sang in his presence a newly composed “mantra”, contrary to siddhanta and to the spirit of devotion, he cut him short: “Such a name is not allowed here.”

To Vraja

He wandered much through holy places, and everywhere his mind was steeped in the rasa of devotion to Krishna. Everything around him reminded him of Krishna's pastimes — above all the pipal and bata, the banyan. On seeing such a tree he would sit beneath it, seeing in it the Vamshi-vata, the banyan under which Krishna played His flute, and it was not easy to move him from there.

On Monday, 12 Phalguna 1347 of the Bengali era (24 February 1941), he set out from Koladvipa — the town of Navadvipa — for Vrindavana, now on foot, now by cart, now by train. In Katwa he spent two days under a banyan by the station; in Bhagalpur, a day under a banyan by the station and four days by the Ganga; in Gaya, three days by the Phalgu; in Benares, three days in a boat at Dashashvamedha Ghata; in Ayodhya, three days by the Sarayu, three hours of them under a banyan; in Prayaga, ten days at the Triveni; in Mathura, two days at Vishrama Ghata. In Vrindavana he stayed eight days at Vamshi-vata, nine at Madhyachura on the Yamuna, a day at the temple of Govindaji and two at Kalidaha. In Nandagrama he sat eight days under a tamala on the eastern bank of Surya-kunda, two days at Pavana-sarovara and four at the roots of a pilu tree; and then he spent nine more days at Vamshi-vata Ghata in Vrindavana. After three months, in Jyaishtha, he returned to Navadvipa-dhama.

His companions related that in Vraja he would now sing of Krishna's pastimes, now glorify Navadvipa-dhama, now laugh like a madman, now speak indistinctly, now keep silent for a long time — and his absorption captivated their hearts.

The Journey in the Chronicle of the Journal “Gaudiya”

The weekly “Gaudiya” recorded his journeys in later years too, from 1943 to 1947: to Ambika-Kalna, Kharagpur, Baleshvar, Soro, Bhadrak, Khurda Road and Purushottama (Puri), and then again to Gaya, Kashi, Saidpur, Patna, Munger and other places. One of these journeys, from Kharagpur to Bhagalpur, the servants of the Gaudiya Math recorded almost day by day, from 26 August to 1 January — with his words and songs. The chronicle does not name the year; apparently it is 1943–1944[5].

Kharagpur and Medinipur

He arrived in Kharagpur on 26 August, having eaten nothing for the two days before. He told his servants to look for a “vamshi-vata”, and his tent was pitched under a banyan right in front of the station; there he spent the night. At first he wanted to go to Vrindavana by passenger train via Gomoh, but then he had two bullock carts brought and, however much the respected townsmen urged him to go by train, he held his ground. By rickshaw and the cart of a Hindu driver he reached a banyan by Upendra Maiti's road at Nutan Bazar in Medinipur and stayed there four days.

At that time Srila Bhakti Dayita Madhava Goswami Maharaj was living in Medinipur, at the Shyamananda Gaudiya Math. Learning that Babaji was passing through the town by cart, he sent a disciple to invite him to the math. Babaji promised to come, but on entering the town he saw a pipal, recognised in it a Vamshi-vata — and stayed beneath it. Then Srila Madhava Maharaj came to him himself, and Babaji, remembering his love for Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, treated him to sweet rice. Apparently this meeting took place in just those four days by Upendra Maiti's road[6].

Gaya

He spent one night in the village of Godapiyasal, in the morning was at Shalboni and asked whether there was a station there. By a train at three in the morning he reached Gomoh and stayed on the

platform, and the next day, with two servants, by the Delhi Mail, he arrived in Gaya-dhama at about half past one in the afternoon. Here he wished to stay near the temple of Sri Vishnu-pada. Local people invited him to the veranda of an open dharmashala by the Phalgu, but he remained in his tent on the sand of the bank. The whole day of Radhashtami he spent in supreme joy. And after two or three days he was speaking of Vrindavana again.

In Gaya he sang: “I will not go where Nitai is not; I will not look upon the faces of those who oppose Nitai.” The pandas of Gaya asked him to offer pinda to his ancestors. He asked where Gayasura had come from and heard out the whole legend; and the pandas added: “Here, during Ramachandra's exile, Sri Sita Devi offered pinda to Maharaja Dasharatha — you too should offer it.” Babaji replied: “People perform the dharma of giving gifts — and where do they go once they have crossed the Vaitarani? I cross it on a cart! I am kept outside the rules of the Vedas: I do neither the work of the Vedas nor the work of the injunctions — how am I to offer pinda to my parents?” And pointing to his Deities, he added: “They here will not let me — now let us see what happens.” “Ask your Thakuras and do as They say,” the pandas insisted, but he only repeated: “Hari, lover of His devotees!”

A wrestler laid a “Hanuman-yantra” amulet before him and asked him to return it with a blessing. “You have come to wheedle a blessing!” Babaji said sternly. “Take it — why did you throw it here?” — and the man picked up the amulet himself and left. And to Sri Gopala Babaji complained: “In Puri there are pandas, and here there are pandas, but no Harinama. I know nothing — now You Yourself deal with the pandas. You have left both Vedic and worldly dharma — who will drink water from Your hands? Gayanatha has no home, and Kashinatha has none either.”

Kashi

From 25 Ashvina he lived in Kashi-dhama on the bank of the Ganga — at “the field where Sri Sanatana received instruction”; of his days there the servants of the Sri Sanatana Gaudiya Math told. To his Thakura he said: “You have seen Gayanatha — now see Kashinatha. In Puri You saw Lokanatha — here he is Kashinatha. You will go to Prayaga — there are troops there, but there are sadhus too, only he does not reveal himself to everyone. You will go to Vrindavana, and then where? In the rains, when the Ganga rises, in Ashadha, You will return to Navadvipa.”

Almost every day he sang Srila Narottama Dasa Thakura's song “Nitai-pada-kamala” — “The lotus feet of Nitai”. At the line “When Nitai's mercy comes, you will attain Radha-Krishna in Vraja” he would say: “There is talk of Vraja, but whether I shall go I cannot say.” At the words that Nitai's feet are cooler than ten million moons he sighed: “Then why have I not been cooled?”

Once, smelling a stick of incense, he said: “Nothing has any fragrance — or the fragrance is there, but the nose does not catch it.” And he recalled a saying from his former life beyond the Brahmaputra: “What is a washerman to do in a land of naked sannyasis?” — so too a speaker without listeners. “When Mahaprabhu came, hundreds of thousands flocked to Him; let us see how many come now. The Mayavadis of Kashi reviled Mahaprabhu then, and Tapana Mishra and Chandrashekhara suffered for it; let them come now — we shall see who is able.” And another time he said: “Wherever I go, sorrow goes with me — the prema of separation.”

On his very first day in Kashi he himself chose the place for his tent. An old woman would not let him have it: “This is my place, I have sat here twenty years!” He drove her off: “Her place! Her purchased ghata! So Nitai's own estate is lost!” — and he sang: “Yama, run, run! In the domain of Nitai-chanda your turn is over.” The old woman tried to have him driven out with the help of worldly people. The chronicle remarks: a soul that only pretends to live in Kashi and offends the feet of Shambhu — the king of Vaishnavas — and of the dhama itself is possessed by such an evil thought when it stands at the door of death; she offended the feet of a paramahamsa, one of Gaura-Nityananda's own, as Ramachandra

Khan once offended the feet of Nityananda.

He sang: “One who has no connection with this — his life has passed in vain” — and added: “I have nothing to do with all this; I see none of it.” This line he repeated later too. He sang also of intimate service: “Following the sakhis, I shall take up loving service”, “The sakhi in the form of the guru is on the left; I shall fan with a chamara Him who stands in the threefold-bending pose.”

On 3 Karttika he suddenly wished to go straight to Vrindavana, ordered transport to be arranged and even agreed to the train — on condition that, apart from him, not a single passenger travel on the entire train. When they came to say the carriage had been booked, he made no reply, and long afterwards said: “I will not go now.” — “But everything is booked, the money is paid!” — “Why did you pay? How should I know whether I shall go? You paid — very well; I will not go.” That day from morning he smiled to himself and spoke much; with tears of joy he sang “Nitai and Gaura dance in the house of Gauridasa”, and at times he spoke of Kalna and its Amli-tala.

When a bather cried out “Sita-Rama!”, Babaji remarked: “‘Sita-Rama’ lives on the throne, and ‘Hare-Rama’ on the bank of the Sarayu.” And with a laugh: “All the sadhus get stuck at Gopala. There is no madhura-rasa now — I have no madhura-rasa; here it is shanta, dasya, sakhya, vatsalya, up to that.” And looking at a banana (rambha) before Thakura, he played on the word: “Rambha — Rambhavati, Kalavati, Lilavati — that is in Puri.” When a servant brought water for the service, he said to himself: “Without service the pure is not attained; Raya says: service is the way to the pure.” And suddenly: “What use is the thread? Mahaprabhu Himself said: “If a person has realised the truth about Krishna, he is a true Guru, whether he be a brahmana, a sannyasi or a shudra”. (CC, Madhya 8.127) And again: “In the service of Krishna birth or eminence is not taken into account at all”. (CC, Antya 4.67)”

Once in Kashi a prakrita-sahajiya who had earlier sung lila-kirtana before him came to him. Chewing betel and laughing, he shouted loudly “Jaya Nitai, Jaya Nitai!”, as if glorifying Babaji, and, breaking the flow of hari-katha, struck up “The cowherd boy of Vraja has come”. A servant of the Sanatana Gaudiya Math stopped him and asked him to listen to Babaji; feigning embarrassment, the man began to take his leave. Babaji raised his hand before his face: “Excessive devotion is the mark of a thief!” — “How have I become a thief?” — “With my lips I say ‘Hari’, but in my mind there is something else.” The mask fell, and the hypocrite left.

A stout woman in saffron, assuming the air of a venerable elder, said: “Baba, I saw you at Baral Ghata in Navadvipa! Bless me to chant the name of Hari much; I am a daughter-in-law of Advaita's family.” He replied: “Above three locks — six, above them — sixteen, and still the thief breaks in and steals. A family has only one lock: what can it do? Go, go to your Baral Ghata.”

To a woman with bel leaves he said: “I have seen, I have seen — this is in Navadvipa too,” and, indicating a Shiva-linga with a gesture: “Here it is all the same. When Gaura was small, He used to go naked to the bathing ghata of the Ganga. The girls would mould a Shiva-linga there and worship it, and He would joke with them: ‘Rather than Shiva, won't you worship Me?’”[7]

When people asked him: “What will become of us, what are we to do?” — he sang: “Worship Nitai and you will attain Gaura; joylessness will go, and the highest joy will dawn.” To some he answered only: “Hari, lover of His devotees!” And once he said with a smile: “I have searched the whole world and not found a man after my own heart.”

On Tuesday, 9 Karttika (26 October), he sang: “In Vrindavana You were the little butter thief — the stealer of cream, butter, clothes and hearts,” and asked his servants: “Do you see the house of Chandrashekhara? Mahaprabhu lived there, and now no one can even tell. This is Kashi of stone — Vishvanatha is not here.” On 11 Karttika (28 October) he said: “This One (Sri Krishna) is a robber, and That One (Sri Gaurasundara) is the root of all cheats: He will not be caught! From Gaya He came to

Kashi; I came to Kashi — and He went back to Gaya. He has no home: He became a vairagi, left His native land, dressed as a fakir — rags on His body, a kaupina about His loins."

To an old woman in saffron he said: "The Doms herd pigs and keep them within bounds by a mantra — not one leaves the herd, except perhaps one or two. So too are worldly people: they cannot leave the world, and if they do leave it, they go to live in Kashi. But Vishvanatha is not in Kashi — this is Kashi of stone; he lives in the spiritual, golden Kashi, and now roams the cremation grounds. Here on the ghata they have seated Hara-Gauri, set out a plate — and the coins pour in! I saw the same in Navadvipa."

On Saturday, 13 Karttika (30 October), the day of his departure, he said: "Whoever hopes in You, You ruin utterly; to one You give money, from another You take it away. 'There is no escape from offence to Your feet' — how will you stop it? Who will save? To whom shall I speak, who will listen? I have not a drop of attachment to the Vaishnavas"[8]. And before setting off: "Renunciation and enjoyment, majesty and sweetness… I smell nothing — no fragrance: the flowers have no scent, nor the fruits. 'One moon dispels the darkness' — what can many stars do? Is there a fragrant flower blooming anywhere?" All that day he fasted, and at eleven at night the boat left Kashi.

Down the Ganga to Patna

On 14 Karttika (31 October) the tent was pitched under a banyan on the bank of the Ganga near the village of Saidpur, twenty miles from Kashi. On 15 and 16 Karttika the boat drifted downstream by night. On 16 Karttika (2 November) he said: "Mercy to living beings, taste for the Name, service to the Vaishnavas — apart from this there is no eternal dharma." To the Deity: "You have seen the Ganga of Kashi — now You will see the Ganga of Patna." Near the village of Ghoshpur in Ghazipur district milk was obtained for Thakura; a pumpkin without its stalk, brought by a villager, he did not accept. Cooking after sunset, he sang to Thakura: "In sorrow and in joy we live in a boat: now ghee and honey, now fasting. I shall bring wild greens and cook them without salt — put two or three morsels in Your mouth." That day he himself honoured prasada of only rice and boiled vegetables.

Patna

On the morning of 18 Karttika (4 November), at Chhapra, the boat was tied to a steamer, and at four in the afternoon he reached the ghata of the Engineering College in Patna; here the tent was pitched, and he stayed in Patna until 15 November. On 19 Karttika he said: "They have locked Him up in prison. How much He used to eat — and now rice of three chhataks. The same smell as in Kashi I have caught in Patna too." On 20 Karttika, when a servant complained that rats had eaten food left uncovered, he remarked: "Now they steal in order to eat, but give with respect — and they will not eat." He questioned a Ramanuji sadhu from Patna about Harihara-chhatra and wanted to go there, but the next day changed his mind.

On 21 Karttika (7 November) he taught in Mahaprabhu's words: "Do not eat luxurious food and do not wear costly clothes" (CC, Antya 6.236), and added: "Do not chew betel, do not smoke tobacco." And he sang: "Leaving the comfort of sleep on an ornate bed, when shall I be covered with the dust of Vraja?" Seeing an old sadhu after his bath, he joyfully quoted the words of Hanuman: "The Lord of Sri and the Lord of Janaki are one and the same Supreme Soul; and yet my all in all is lotus-eyed Rama". Then, saying that King Kali is very mighty, he told a legend: when Kali came, Krishna told Narada that it was time for Him to depart. "But what of the souls?" asked Narada. "They will attain Me by feeding a brahmana sixteen dishes." — "And the poor?" — "With flowers, water and tulasi." — "And those crippled from birth?" — "By uttering My name once at the end of the day with all their heart."

A resident of Patna asked him for instruction. “What instruction?” Babaji replied. “A mother looks at her son's belly — is he fed? A wife looks at her husband's waistband — has he brought money? From worldly life Krishna is far away.” — “How then can one leave worldly life?” — “Sadhus live by the Sarayu and say ‘Sita-Rama’: there is joy there, no joylessness. On Duryodhana's side is joylessness, on Yudhishthira's side happiness. Happiness and sorrow are two brothers; enjoyment and renunciation — one enjoys, another renounces.”

On 28 Karttika (14 November) he called out loudly: “Hari bol, Hari bol! Say ‘Gaura-Nitai’! So they say in Navadvipa and in Mayapur. Around the temple in Mayapur there are houses, and the service is under a nim tree. Once I went to Mayapur with a torn blanket and a water pot. Shachinandana Gosai came and took my pot; I sat. A little later Shachinandana Gosai returned the pot and left; and I left too.” Shachinandana Gosai is Mahaprabhu Himself.

On Monday, 29 Karttika (15 November), the day of departure, he offered balya-bhoga to the Deities in the morning, closed the tent, quickly cooked, offered to Thakura and honoured prasada at three o'clock. The servants of the Gaudiya Math bowed at his feet and sang songs of Sri Pancha-tattva — “Nitai-pada-kamala” and others — and he listened joyfully. Then he boarded the boat with his Deities and set off at about half past six in the evening. On 30 Karttika the boat lay at anchor near the village of Rupas, and on 2 Agrahayana (18 November) he was in great joy at the sight of the Ganga and in the evening reached the ghata of Munger.

Munger

On 3 Agrahayana (19 November) he had the tent pitched at Chandi Ghata, away from the town, and quoted a line from Srila Narottama's “Prema-bhakti-chandrika”: “Hearing Govinda's roar, all will flee of themselves, as elephants flee at the roar of a lion”[9]. He asked Sri Gopala: “Where will You get curd and butter?” No curd could be found, and that day he did not offer balya-bhoga but cooked greens. “In the house of Srila Narottama Thakura there are six thieves,” he said, meaning the six Deities of Kheturi — Sri Gauranga, Sri Ballavikantha, Sri Krishna, Sri Brajamohana, Sri Radhakanta and Sri Radharamana, — “and in Mayapur there is one thief, Sri Vishvambhara.”

The next day he said: “Maya has seized all these people. The birds, too, eat and drink — and in them too is the urge of the senses. There it is, maya!” And on 5 Agrahayana (21 November) he recalled the Lord's words: “The devotee is the friend of My life, listen, Arjuna: through the mouth of the devotee I take a second meal,” and asked: who, then, eats and who gives? These words he repeated later too. “You are going to the land the Pandavas left behind — we shall see. Six Gosvamis — and six enemies, six thieves; six thieves in Narottama's house, one in Mayapur.” After the midnight prasada he sang “Having conquered maya, you cannot leave her…”, “Be merciful, O Vaishnava Gosai…”, Narottama's song “Gora pahun na bhajiya mainu” — “Not worshipping Gaura, my Lord, I perished…” — and others.

Bhagalpur

On 6 Agrahayana (22 November) he sang joyfully from the morning, had a boat brought for Bhagalpur and set off at about half past two, and at noon on 7 Agrahayana, Tuesday 23 November, he landed at Mayaganj Ghata in Bhagalpur[10]. Here, on the bank of the Ganga, under a vamshi-vata, a cloth tent was pitched, and in it he lived together with the Deities of his bhava-seva.

On 9 Agrahayana he asked how many days' journey it was from Bhagalpur to Godavari Ghata and what holy places lay along the way. At night, at nearly one o'clock, he made an offering to Thakura, honoured prasada and talked long with Thakura. And in the morning, seeing palms all around, he remembered Vrindavana: “Here is Talavana, here Khajuravana — stay a little while in Bhagalpur,” and he sang of Talavana, Khajuravana and Madhuvana.

11 Agrahayana (27 November): “He performs ashtanga-pranama. Where there is fearlessness, there is fear too; it is hard to be fearless.” And he sang: “I will not give, I will not give any other burden; I want neither gems nor ornaments”; “Once I saw You in the womb — and now I seek and do not find You, Hari,” — “Hari, when shall I see You again?” 15 Agrahayana (1 December): “The intimate and the external: the intimate one does what is inward, the external one what is outward — to each according to his mind. With Yashoda — up to shanta, dasya, sakhya, vatsalya. Where now in Vrindavana are Yashoda and Krishna? Where are the sixteen thousand gopis? Who churns curd and butter now?” And seeing a forest he sang: “Who is it that plays the flute beneath the Vamshi-tata in Bhandiravana?”

17 Agrahayana (3 December): “Where shall I go? I see no path; wherever I go, there I shall sit. Who performs this service? You have set up house. Srila Narottama Thakura set up house — he founded six services,” that is, the service of six Deities. And the next day he spoke of Majidpur, the land the Pandavas left behind.

20 Agrahayana (6 December): “A dwarf from birth — what use pulling at him? Maya holds us fast,” and he sang: “I have fallen into the snare of the wicked, the whale of lust has swallowed me — O Lord, save me!”, “Having become maya's servant, I nurse countless desires, and the memory of Your feet has gone far away”, “Apart from the mercy of the sadhu I see no other means,” — “Who is this sadhu?” 22 Agrahayana (8 December), remembering Navadvipa: “At Navadvipa the Ganga bends to the right — and here to the right as well; ahead a sandbank can be seen, as from Navadvipa one sees the sandbank of Mayapur.”

On 24 Agrahayana (10 December) he taught: “Do not live with unbelievers,” and quoted a verse of Chanakya: a friend who ruins your affairs behind your back but speaks sweetly to your face the wise man will reject, like a pot of poison with milk only at its brim. “Whose company do you keep? ‘I have fallen into the snare of the wicked.’ What a maya! How to be free? ‘I see not a trace of deliverance’, ‘the more I see, the more I suffer’, ‘so weeps the helpless one’ — and now he cannot even weep. I see no path. What shall I answer when Yama comes? He will not listen to words!” 28 Agrahayana (14 December): “In this land there is no Harinama, and yet I came here; I do not know where to go now. ‘The senses have fallen under the sway of enemies…’ — what remedy is there now?”

30 Agrahayana (16 December): “One thing after another; three days have passed — let us see how many more.” He sang: “With a sick body one does not serve Krishna: where there is illness, there the mind is”; “Fifty-six dandas of bhajana, four of rest, and in sleep the darshana of Radha-Krishna”; “Association with sadhus is the essence of all scriptures: from a moment's association with sadhus comes the darshana of Krishna”[11], — “association with sadhus goes on — where is the darshana of Krishna?” “At Gauranga's sweet pastimes even stone melts”; “I say ‘Gauranga’ — and my body trembles; I say ‘Hari, Hari’ — and tears pour from my eyes,” — “Does the body tremble, do tears pour? Neither. Only singing? The singing goes on.” “Piety is the abode of happiness, but do not utter its name; reject both piety and liberation,” — “and yet the mind wants happiness.”

Once several Marwaris persistently pressed him: “How long will the war go on?” He answered with annoyance: “I know nothing of all that,” and the businessmen went away empty-handed.

In Bhagalpur everything reminded him of the holy lands. The palm and date groves, Bhandiravana all around — this was Vrindavana; the flow of the Ganga and its sandbanks — Navadvipa-dhama. “It is good, I am in solitude,” he said on 3 Pausha (19 December). “In Jyaishtha there is the fair at Sri Ramakeli; I shall go there — there will be much joy. But these months must be spent here. Here too are the outlines of Navadvipa: ahead, the sandbank of Sri Mayapur; on the other bank, Svarupganj; the Ganga flows south, as in Navadvipa. Talavana, Khajuravana, Bhandiravana, a bamboo grove — I am happy beneath the Vamshi-tata.” Now laughing, now weeping, he was immersed in the joy of his

realisation.

For several days he displayed — to outward eyes — the pastime of a cold and a cough, and acted as if in defiance of the illness: he did not shield himself from the cold but embraced it. He ate curd and sour things, early in the morning poured ice-cold water over his head from a clay pot inscribed with the names of the Ganga and the Yamuna, and morning and evening, in bitter cold, he stayed with his body uncovered. The chronicle remarks: his every act is wondrous and beyond the ordinary, lying outside human understanding. On 1 Pausha (17 December), early in the morning, in the cold, he cooked and offered to Thakura khichri and sweet rice: every year in the month of Pausha he offered khichri each morning.

On 9 Pausha (25 December) some Marwari women came to him: they left a coin or two, looked, and went away. “I go to see with my own eyes the One I love,” he said. “They came, looked and left — is that love? They left a coin or two!” The next morning he told a servant to clear and water the ground by the little date palms near his dwelling, but not to cut the branches. And again he recalled the second meal through the mouth of the devotee: “How will the second meal be? Where is a devotee to be found? Who speaks of ‘madhukari-bhiksha’ — who will give and who will take? What fruit does the giver seek? Alms are given, yes — but how am I to take madhukari? They have seated me here.” And loudly he told his servants: “Chant Harinama!”

On 13 Pausha he said: “‘With His devotees, in the rasas of love, He speaks of love’ — but there is no bhajana at all: what talk of love can there be?” 15 Pausha (31 December): “I shall dash my head on a stone, I shall enter fire — where shall I find Gauranga, the treasury of virtues?”; “Worship Gaura and you will attain Nitai; worship Nitai and you will attain Gaura”; “The snake is wicked and the scoundrel is wicked — both are wicked, but the scoundrel no means can tame.”

The last entry of the chronicle is Saturday, 16 Pausha, 1 January. “‘The senses are under the sway of enemies, I have forgotten Gaura's feet’ — let us see what happens when one forgets Gaura's feet… ‘The touch of the Ganga purifies in time, but Your darshana at once: such is Your nature’ — you have travelled along the Ganga; have you been purified? It is darshana that purifies.” And of Narottama's song “Jivante marana bhela”: “Narottama sang: ‘Living, I have died’; what use remaining longer? Seeing the load of my sins, even Gaura went away. ‘Always reject bad company’ — I shall leave it; perhaps You will take me. I will not call — You Yourself must come; if You cannot come alone, bring Nitai; if not that, bring the devotees; if You come in secret, come at least once into my heart; come once, let me see You.” And he sang: “Gaurachandra, Gaurahari, come just once!”

Answers to Questions

Usually he was absorbed in his service, interfered in nothing and spoke little. To questions he mostly kept silent or answered indirectly. When he instructed, he seldom quoted scripture — he spoke from his own realisation, in two or three short phrases that deeply moved the listener. Visitors wrote down some of his answers.

One man came constantly and kept asking how to attain God. For a long time Babaji did not answer, and then one day suddenly asked: “What do you want?” — “To find God.” — “Weep.” To others he said: “There is no joy here until you worship Gaura-Nitai: that is our eternal world, and yours is illusion; happiness here is like a baby's laughing or crying in its sleep.” “The mercy of Krishna is attained by weeping. But who weeps truly? Shed tears of love and you will attain the Lord's mercy,” and he would quote the line: “With my lips I say ‘Hari’, but I do otherwise — and so tears of love do not flow from my eyes.” The same thought he flung in the face of the sahajiya in Kashi.

Among the recorded answers are also those he gave on the road. To the question “What are we to do?” — “Worship Nitai and you will attain Gaura.” To the question how to know the mercy of Krishna and the Vaishnavas — the words about Him who ruins those who hope in Him, and about the inescapable offence to His feet. To the question where happiness lies — in renunciation or in enjoyment — the answer about Duryodhana and Yudhishthira. To the question whether he had been to Mayapur — the story of Shachinandana Gosai and the water pot: “some call this place Mayapur, some Navadvipa”. And to the question how to be freed from the sway of the senses — the line about Govinda's roar.

One gentleman came often and kept begging for mercy. One day, losing patience, Babaji took off his kaupina and held it out to him: “You want my mercy? Here it is — take it!” — and the man recoiled in fright. We hear that all perfection comes by the mercy of the Vaishnavas, but we lack the sincerity to accept that mercy; nor is there real feeling in our singing of the songs of the mahajanas — we shake off the dust of the holy places without knowing its worth.

Departure

Srila Vamshidasa Babaji Maharaja left this world on the fourth lunar day of the bright half of the month of Shravana (shravana shukla chaturthi); by our calendar this is Gaura-chaturthi of the month of Shridhara (in 2026, 16 August). Neither the year nor the place of his departure, nor the site of his samadhi, have been preserved by the sources.

Significance

The life of Srila Vamshidasa Babaji is an example of devotion that does not fit the measures of the outer world. His every act is beyond the ordinary and incomprehensible to the worldly mind, and in his wanderings he poured out causeless mercy and purified the earth. His sharpness with hypocrites and petitioners — with the sahajiya, the “daughter-in-law of Advaita's family”, the wrestler with the amulet, the gentleman begging for mercy — is the same restraint for the good of souls as that of Srila Gaurakishora Dasa Babaji. Therefore Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, bowing to him from a distance, taught his disciples not to judge him by the rules of a sadhaka, but to honour him as a paramahamsa whose heart belongs wholly to Gaura-Nitai and Radha-Govinda.

1. His words about his former life, about being “in accord” with no sampradaya, and about having “not a drop of attachment to the Vaishnavas” are the speech of a paramahamsa's humility, who speaks of himself as a fallen soul; they must not be taken literally. According to the chronicle of the “Gaudiya”, he followed in the footsteps of Srila Gaurakishora Dasa Babaji; from whom he received initiation and the babaji's dress, the sources do not say.

2. The story of the unlocked hut is given after Haridasa Dasa's book “Gaudiya-vaishnava-jivana” (vol. 2). His reproaches to the Deities, like his jests and complaints to Them, are the speech of love: for him the Deity is the Lord Himself, living and near, not an image.

3. The offering of tobacco is no example to imitate: for a sadhaka tobacco is an intoxicant renounced in service (as Babaji himself taught in Patna: “do not smoke tobacco”). But the service of a paramahamsa who, in spiritual feeling, lives beside the Divine Couple of Vraja is not measured by the rules of a sadhaka: so he served Radha and Govinda in his intimate feeling, without offering this to Nitai-Gauranga. That is exactly why Srila Bhaktisiddhanta bowed to him from a distance but did not allow beginners either to imitate him or to judge him.

4. One of the biographies names Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura as the author of this song; the chronicle of the “Gaudiya”, where the same line is heard from Babaji himself in Patna, does not name the author.

5. The year is not given in the chronicle. The combination of dates and weekdays fits both 1943/44 and 1948/49; the Marwaris' question about the war and the records of journeys in 1943–1947 apparently point to the autumn of 1943 — the beginning of 1944.

6. The account of the meeting with Srila Madhava Maharaj bears no date; that it belongs to the same journey as the chronicle of the “Gaudiya” is our own comparison.

7. This is a childhood play of the Lord: little Gaura, Himself the Supreme Personality of Godhead, in jest reveals to the girls that the true object of worship is He Himself; Shiva is His greatest devotee, and there is no disrespect to Shiva in it. Babaji recalls it as a reminder that worship in Navadvipa must lead to Gaura. In the text Gaura’s words are softened; in full the

account reads: “When the girls moulded a Shiva-linga and worshipped it, He would say to them mischievously: ‘Instead of worshipping Shiva, can’t you worship my “this one”?’” — the words “this one” are set in quotation marks in the account; they are spoken by a naked little boy. It is a child’s mischief with no mundane sense in it: the Lord, having appeared as a child, claims worship for Himself.

8. The same words have also been preserved as an answer to the question how to know the mercy of Krishna or of the Vaishnavas; there they speak of offence to the feet of the “Vaishnava-thakura”.

9. In another retelling of this line deer are named instead of elephants.

10. In the daily entry 22 November is called a Sunday, while in the summary of the journey it is a Monday; 24 November stands there beside 9 Agrahayana, which falls on the 25th. The dates in the text follow the summary.

11. In “Chaitanya-charitamrita” this thought ends differently: “The scriptures declare that even a single moment of sadhu-sanga (association with pure devotees of God) is enough to attain the perfection of life”. (CC, Madhya 22.54) Babaji sings it with the ending “comes the darshana of Krishna”.